We spoke for close to an hour, and continued a fortnight later with a second mulaqat. It seemed to me that he wanted to tell the world a great many things and felt helpless that he could not. I scribbled almost without pause in my little pocket book.

Excerpts from the interview:

There are so many contradictory images of Afzal. Which Afzal am I meeting?

Is it? But as far as I'm concerned there is only one Afzal. That is me.

Who is that Afzal?

(A moments' silence.) Afzal is a young, enthusiastic, intelligent, idealistic young man. Afzal is a Kashmiri, influenced like many thousands in the Kashmir Valley in the political climate of the early 1990s . . . [He] was a JKLF member and crossed over to the other side of Kashmir, but in a matter of weeks got disillusioned and came back and tried to live a normal life but was never allowed to do so by the security agencies. [They] picked me up, tortured the pulp out of me, [I was] electrocuted, frozen in cold water, dipped in petrol, smoked with chillies—you name it—falsely implicated in a case, with no lawyer, no fair trial, and finally condemned to death. The lies the police told were propagated by you [people] in the media. And that perhaps created what the Supreme Court referred to as the 'collective conscience of the nation'. To satisfy that 'collective conscience' I'm condemned to death. That is the Mohammad Afzal you are meeting.

(After a moments' silence, he continued.) But I wonder whether the outside world knows anything about this Afzal. I ask you, did I get a chance to tell my story? Do you think justice is done? Would you like to hang a person without giving him a lawyer? Without a fair trial? Without listening to what he had to go through in life? Democracy doesn't mean all this, does it?

Can we begin with your life? Your life before the case . . .

It was a turbulent political period in Kashmir when I was growing up. Maqbul Bhatt was hanged. The situation was volatile. The people of Kashmir decided to fight an electoral battle once again to resolve the Kashmir issue through